



June 2006

Piracy

Dear Digit,
Piracy is considered a crime all over the world, but let's face it, India is still a developing country and 90 per cent of the populous are middle class or live below the poverty line. The price of a basic computer is not more than Rs 20,000, but not everyone can afford to buy legitimate software. Pirated CDs cost between Rs 30 and Rs 200. Unless the Americans realise that they need to price their products more affordably in Indian rupees, piracy should be made legal! Piracy is playing a major role in promoting the use of computers in India, which is not a bad thing. You may not agree with my views and not even publish this letter but please do look into this piracy issue because if this stops—we middle class Indians will be technologically handicapped.

Razil (Kuku)
Akhtar

Piracy Creates Customers

Today's pirates are tomorrow's potential customers. Though pirated software is cheap or free, they have their own disadvantages. They cannot be updated online and there is no customer care service for them. Be it an OS like Windows XP or antivirus software like Norton or Quick Heal, they all need to be updated. Some people may be happy with older versions, but all are not. There is a section of pirated software users who use it because of ignorance and financial problems.

54 per cent of the people in our country are below 25 years of age, so 90

per cent of them do not earn their own living. When they do, should they buy a home, a car or legal software? People don't buy software because they cannot!

What if suddenly some technology like hardware integration is done which bars you from installing a pirated OS on your system like in the case of 900 series chipset motherboards from Intel, which does not install Windows 98? People are forced to use Windows XP (may be pirated) and not all can suddenly switch over to Linux - human nature resists change.

If you analyze the problem of piracy from a different point of view you will find that piracy may have created a huge army of potential customers who are training themselves to give a big boost to the software industry. Patience is the virtue.

Lokesh Bazaj, Raniganj,
West Bengal

Dear Razil and Lokesh,
I share some of your opinions, but not all of them. In an article in the April 2006 issue of *Digit*, I wrote about how piracy may even be good for software vendors. Of course, this does not make it right! I have to disagree with some of your suggestions, like making piracy legal—it's almost as ridiculous as saying that we should not punish murderers, because they are helping us control the population explosion!

The economic situation of our country is *our* problem, not a software vendors'. Yes products could be priced more in tune with our earnings in India, but then maybe our earnings should be more in tune with the rest of the world! But if we earned as much as "Americans", we would have to shut down one of our fastest growing sectors—the BPO industry. So as you can see, things aren't as simple as they seem.

As Lokesh rightly points out, piracy is (hopefully) creating potential customers—so if you use pirated software right now and can afford to go legal, please do so now! Moreover, encourage your friends to do so too. Finally, there's a lot more open source software out there, many of which offer you nearly all the capability of paid software. If money is your problem, go Open Source!

—Agent001

Teaching The Teachers!

This is my second letter to *Digit*. The first one was a complaint letter due to a faulty copy of *SKOAR!*, but thanks to your customer service I received a brand new copy within two days. I just can't forget the first day I picked up *Digit*. It was 21st December 2004 and from that day my

life changed! Today I am considered a 'Tech Encyclopaedia' by friends. Your May issue was really awesome. *Fast Track to Photoshop* was spectacular. In its initial pages you rightly wrote that most people don't use Photoshop because they think it's very sophisticated. I was wondering how you guys gauge the thinking of a common man so perfectly. Having read your *Fast Track* I indeed realised that it was not very tough and now I am teaching it to computer teachers at my school. I would like to thank you for introducing such a great magazine.

Regards
Rahul Gupta

Dear Rahul,
It is heartening to know that our *Fast Track to Photoshop* was a delight for you and also helped you learn a few tricks of the software. It has always been our endeavour to scale up the learning of our readers and increase their knowledge quotient in technology.

—Associate Editor

Wasting Money On Digit?

Congratulations for *Digit's* 5th anniversary and best wishes for the years ahead. Your fourth anniversary issue was the first issue I bought, and since then I have never been disheartened till now. Your June issue cost Rs 200 and I had expected much more than what you have given on CD's and the so called dual-layered DVD, although the content of the magazine and fast track was superb. CD, DVD content was not up to the mark. Frankly the free game CD (*Monster Truck Madness 2*) was not useful and a waste of money. On DVD you had nothing more than some very old movies. But the articles like five decades of technology were interesting. My complaints are before you. I know, you would not publish this first ever letter of mine. Still if you would do something regarding my complaints it will be worth writing this letter.

Neeraj Singh

Dear Neeraj,
Thanks for your appreciation and an honest feedback. It's always a challenge to strike a balance for our readers: Will they like the issue? Will they flame us? While we have received e-mails that echo your sentiments, we've also had people who liked the game and some more who were really interested in the Business Plan contest. Even the movies have received mixed reviews, and many have appreciated the timeless classics that you can't even see on TV today! I